

Blackened fruit jerk tempeh

Looking through cookbooks, you can find dozens of jerk recipes. I added mango to mine and, for the final **bold** touch, blackened the tempeh in a cast-iron skillet. I found out by accident—when ripe mangoes were not available—that fresh pineapple works equally as well as mango. As I mention every chance I get, a cast-iron skillet is indispensable in the **bold** cook's kitchen, not to mention on camping trips. This cooking technique really helps make the dish special. Serve with corn relish and mashed potatoes.

½ to 1 fresh Scotch bonnet or habañero pepper, ribs and seeds removed, or hot sauce, to taste

3 garlic cloves, minced

1 teaspoon grated fresh ginger

4 scallions, coarsely chopped

1 large mango, peeled, seeded, and coarsely chopped

2 tablespoons dark rum

1 tablespoon molasses

Juice of 1 lime

1 tablespoon balsamic vinegar

1 tablespoon olive oil

2 tablespoons unrefined cane sugar

1 teaspoon allspice

1 teaspoon dried thyme

½ teaspoon cinnamon

¼ teaspoon grated nutmeg

¼ teaspoon ground cloves

2 packages (8 ounces each) tempeh [500g total]

2 tablespoons vegetable oil

1. In a blender or food processor, **puree** the hot pepper, garlic, ginger, scallions, mango, rum, molasses, lime juice, vinegar, and olive oil. Add the sugar, allspice, thyme, cinnamon, nutmeg, and cloves. Blend well. Jerk sauce should be thick, but sometimes it can be hard to get the blender turning with all the thick ingredients. If this is the case, gradually add water, 1 tablespoon at a time, to get the blades moving.

2. **Slice** each cake of tempeh in half horizontally so that it is half as thick; then cut each piece in half crosswise so that you end up with 8 cutlets. Put 4 pieces of tempeh into each of 2 large heavy-duty, sealable freezer bags. Pour half the jerk sauce into each bag. Make sure the tempeh pieces are well coated. Seal the bags and lay them on a platter or tray. Refrigerate overnight.
3. Heat a large cast-iron skillet over high heat until very hot. Add 2 teaspoons of the vegetable oil to the pan and heat until beginning to smoke. Add as many cutlets as will fit in a single layer without crowding. **Fry** 1 to 2 minutes on each side, until crisp and blackened. Repeat with the remaining oil and tempeh. Serve immediately.

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